Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 3.2 Guided Notes: Physical Development Across the Lifespan

Unit 3: Development and Learning | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic3.2

Word Bank

Maturation	*Critical Periods*	*Fetal Alcohol Syndrome*
Visual Cliff	*Reflexes*	*Sensitive Periods*
Fine Motor Coordination	*Gross Motor Coordination*	*Rooting Reflex*
Teratogens	*Imprinting*	

1. Before Birth: Prenatal Vulnerabilities

Physical development is largely dictated by _____—the natural, biologically driven process of physical and cognitive development that unfolds over a predictable timeline, independent of experience or training. While the order of developmental milestones is virtually identical across humans (e.g., crawling before walking), the exact timing can vary widely from child to child.

Our physical development begins long before our first breath, and the womb is not a perfectly isolated environment. Maternal illness, genetic mutations, and hormonal imbalances can heavily influence major milestones. Most notably, the developing fetus is highly vulnerable to _____—harmful environmental substances or agents, such as alcohol, nicotine, specific drugs, or infections, that can cross the placental barrier and cause severe birth defects.

The most heavily tested example of a teratogenic effect is _____. This condition occurs due to prenatal alcohol exposure and can result in lifetime challenges, including distinct facial and physical abnormalities, cognitive impairments, and behavioral struggles.

💡 *AP Exam Tip: The specific structural stages of prenatal development—the zygote, embryo, and fetus—are explicitly outside the scope of the AP Psychology Exam!*

Apply It: Maturation or Teratogen?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Nearly every baby around the world begins babbling around the same age, then says their first real word around 12 months, following virtually the same biological timeline regardless of how much anyone tries to speed it up.	
2	A pregnant woman who smokes cigarettes throughout her pregnancy significantly increases the risk of her baby being born with low birth weight and respiratory problems.	

2. Infancy and Childhood: Reflexes, Motors, and Windows

Newborns enter the world equipped with _____, which are inborn, automatic responses to specific stimuli designed to support survival and protect the body. A classic example is the _____: when an infant's cheek is gently touched or stroked, they automatically turn their head toward the stimulus and open their mouth to search for a food source.

Motor Skill Development

As children grow and their nervous systems mature, they develop the independence needed to navigate the world by mastering two distinct types of movement:

- _____: The ability to control large muscle groups to execute broad physical actions like rolling over, sitting up, crawling, walking, and maintaining balance.
- _____: The precise control of small muscle movements, particularly in the hands and fingers, required to accomplish intricate tasks like holding a crayon, writing, buttoning clothing, or using utensils.

Beyond tracking physical milestones, researchers have also investigated how early infants develop the ability to perceive their surroundings. The _____ is a landmark laboratory apparatus used to test depth perception in infants and young animals, using a glass surface that creates the illusion of a sudden drop-off. By observing whether crawling infants were willing to venture across the "cliff" side despite encouragement from a caregiver, researchers demonstrated that the ability to perceive depth develops remarkably early in infancy.

Windows of Growth: Critical vs. Sensitive Periods

The timing of our experiences matters immensely during early childhood. Psychologists distinguish between two kinds of developmental windows:

- _____: Strict, rigid time frames during which an organism is uniquely sensitive to environmental stimuli, and specific abilities or traits must develop normally. If the window passes without exposure, the ability may be permanently lost. For instance, some non-human animals experience a critical period for _____, a rapid and innate form of learning where they form an unbreakable attachment to the very first moving object they see.
- _____: Flexible windows of time when the brain is highly responsive to certain environmental experiences, making learning much easier and more efficient (such as acquiring a primary language). While development is optimal during this phase, a person can still successfully learn the skill later in life, though it may require much more effort.

Apply It: Which Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A toddler carefully practices picking up small cereal pieces one at a time between her thumb and index finger.	
2	A baby learns to crawl, then pull himself up to stand, and eventually take his first wobbly steps across the living room.	

#	Scenario	Concept
3	Researchers place a crawling infant on a glass surface with the illusion of a sudden drop-off to see whether she hesitates or refuses to cross, even when her mother calls encouragingly from the other side.	
4	A baby goose hatches and immediately begins following the first moving object it sees around the barnyard — in this case, a farmer's boot — treating it as its parent for the rest of its life.	

Word Bank

Secondary Sex Characteristics	*Growth Spurt*	*Menopause*
Menarche	*Spermarche*	*Primary Sex Characteristics*
Puberty		

3. Adolescence: The Biological Shift

The transition from childhood to adulthood is triggered by _____, a dramatic developmental stage marked by intense hormonal changes and rapid physical maturation that renders the body capable of biological reproduction. This stage is universally accompanied by an adolescent _____—a rapid acceleration in height and weight.

During puberty, physical traits develop across two distinct categories:

- _____: The internal reproductive organs and external anatomical structures directly involved in reproduction, such as the ovaries, testes, uterus, and genitalia, which mature to full functionality.
- _____: Non-reproductive physical traits that emerge due to hormonal shifts but are not directly required for reproduction. Examples include breast development, voice deepening, and the growth of body hair.

Two essential milestones anchor the onset of adolescent reproductive maturity: _____ (the first occurrence of menstruation in females) and _____ (the first ejaculation of sperm in males).

Apply It: Which Adolescent Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Over the course of just two years, a 13-year-old boy grows nearly seven inches taller and gains noticeable muscle mass, far faster than his growth rate at any other point in his childhood.	
2	A teenage girl's voice doesn't change, but she does notice increased body hair growth and breast development as her hormones shift during puberty — none of which are directly involved in producing a baby.	
3	A 12-year-old girl experiences her very first menstrual period, marking a major milestone in her reproductive development.	

4. Adulthood: Leveling Off and Decline

Adulthood spans the majority of the human life layout. Early adulthood is generally characterized by a peak and general leveling off of physical abilities. However, as individuals move into middle and late adulthood, they experience a varying, natural biological decline.

This aging process leads to a gradual reduction in overall mobility, muscle flexibility, and reaction time. Furthermore, sensory systems undergo changes, resulting in a predictable decline in both visual and auditory sensory acuity. For women in middle adulthood, this period includes _____—the natural biological stage where menstrual cycles permanently conclude, marking the end of structural fertility.

5. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Primary vs. Secondary Characteristics: A common trap on the AP Exam is misclassifying physical changes during puberty. Always ask yourself: Is this structure physically necessary to make or carry a baby? If yes (like ovaries or testes), it is a _____. If it is an external sign of maturity that doesn't actually execute reproduction (like facial hair or widening hips), it is a _____.

⚠️ Critical vs. Sensitive Periods: This is a very common mix-up! To keep them straight, remember that a _____ is a rigid, “now or never” window. If an organism misses this specific window, the developmental trait (like imprinting in animals) will likely never develop normally. A _____ is much more flexible—it is the optimal and easiest time to learn a skill (like a child acquiring a second language), but the skill can still be learned later in life; it will just require much more effort.

6. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. Regardless of their culture or country of origin, virtually all human infants crawl before they walk, and no amount of practice or special training can make a baby walk months earlier than their body is biologically ready for. This natural, predictable, biologically driven process of development is called:

- **A.** A Teratogen
- **B.** A Critical Period
- **C.** Maturation
- **D.** A Sensitive Period

2. A pregnant woman is warned by her doctor that consuming alcohol during pregnancy can cross the placental barrier and cause severe, permanent birth defects and cognitive impairments in her developing baby. Alcohol, in this context, is best classified as a:

- **A.** Teratogen
- **B.** Reflex
- **C.** Critical Period
- **D.** Secondary Sex Characteristic

3. The moment a nurse gently strokes a newborn's cheek, the baby automatically turns her head toward the touch and opens her mouth, searching for a food source, without ever having been taught this behavior. This inborn, automatic survival response is called the:

- **A.** Visual Cliff Response
- **B.** Rooting Reflex
- **C.** Imprinting Response
- **D.** Gross Motor Response

4. Children who are exposed to a second language before the age of seven tend to become fluent with a native-like accent far more easily than adults who begin learning that same language later in life, though adults can still learn it with significantly more effort. This optimal but flexible window for language acquisition is called a:

- **A.** Sensitive Period
- **B.** Puberty Window
- **C.** Critical Period
- **D.** Maturation Period

5. During puberty, a teenage boy's testes fully mature and become capable of producing sperm, directly enabling his biological ability to reproduce. This physical change is best classified as a:

- **A.** Secondary Sex Characteristic
- **B.** Primary Sex Characteristic
- **C.** Reflex
- **D.** Teratogen

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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